veil now channels hate, or predatory animus. At the centre of this is the curious duality of the full-body veil—it seeks to withdraw the wearer from the sexual economy of attraction, to invisibilise her body, but also renders her highly visible in public spaces where the attire is not the default norm. To hide, and yet to be seen: that is the curse that befalls the veiled Muslimah in contemporary India. Coming close on the heels of the Sulli Deals/Bulli Bai controversy, no one missed the theme of public disrobing that played out outside Karnataka's school and college gates. No wonder more than one commentator was drawn into invoking the Draupadi metaphor. The veil specifically disturbs the 'normal' economy of the body, the usual channels of social interchange, so it stirs what has often been seen as a latent psychological motive for the Hindu right: a secret desire for war conquest.

On the other side, the hijab is perhaps also about doing battle: a symbol of defiance, rather than subjugation, from an oppressed minority. In politically besieged times, it has become a part of the vocabulary of dissent. As a marker of religion, asserting one's identity even more wilfully in the face of threat can come to be seen as a noble act in itself. That is perhaps why the hijab-clad woman is, paradoxically, being celebrated by a section of feminists, despite familiar critiques of the hijab as a sign of patriarchy. This is tricky and complex territory, and nowhere have the hijab debates been more intense perhaps than among Muslim feminists—some of it openly on social media, some in closed Whatsapp groups. Often driven to voice their anguish among peers at this regression into what they see as a sign of pre-modern female subservience, anti-hijab feminists who have fought for decades to free women from the attire are wary of expressing their dissent openly at this critical hour (one even turned down a request for a column). That's why K.V. Dhananjay quips that "some progressive Muslim women may even be secretly hoping that the petitioners lose the case", so that a ruling in affirmation of the hijab being 'an essential part of Islam' does not set them back by decades. Alam explicates the nuance, "In either case, the court will take away the woman's agency. Either by negating their right to wear a hijab, or by making it mandatory." On the opposing side, gender activists are perhaps being forced by circumstance, ironically, into the exact place where a PFI might want them: endorsing the hijab unconditionally. At one level, the larger context of Hindutva may be thwarting the organic evolution of progressive streams within Islam. And one of the refrains of the feminist movement—the idea that gender issues cannot be deferred for a better time, and that "there is no good time"—may be under a bit of strain.

The larger context of Hindutva may well be thwarting the organic evolution of progressive streams within Islam

Ghazala Jamil, who teaches law and governance at the Jawaharlal Nehru University in Delhi, would rather not allow extrinsic circumstances to define what, for her, is a clear zone of choice. She sees it as a huge learning moment for the feminist movement, and feels many feminists have indeed evolved a lot in the recent past. The question for her is one of autonomy. "If there are women who are forced to wear *any* dress," she says, "then it's their struggle to shed it. But if there are women who *want* to wear it, and they are being disrobed, it's another thing entirely. Traditional feminists who still peddle the old stock idea that women who want to wear the hijab don't know what they're talking about—don't have agency, or intelligence—haven't learnt much in a changing world."

The contemporary scenario—Karnataka being an example—can seem puzzling at first glance. The spectacle of tens of thousands of young Muslim women in hijab or even the full-body veil, including in places where it was never a traditional attire, stands out on the social landscape. In conversations for this article, respondents from places as varied as eastern UP, the Malvani coast and the heart of Mappila Kerala attested that they never saw their mothers and grandmothers in anything like the full burqa. Madampat, for instance, says: "I come from a very orthodox Salafi family, in a village in Malappuram. My mother is a retired schoolteacher, 71 now. I have only ever seen her in a sari, except with long-sleeved blouse and a *makkana* (scarf). The burqa was non-existent in my region till the 1990s, except for Hajj-returned ladies and women of the region's highest clerical family, who claim Saudi origin. Now the place swarms with it. The thing is that Saudi-inspired Salafi Islam commands only 10 per cent of Muslims, but their influence nowadays is widespread on the rest, what we call customary Islam."

There's obviously a polyvalency at play here. In one sense, what's derided as 'Arabisation'—seen as a kind of exhibitionist Islamism—is also an aspect of globalisation. Hijabs and abayas styled by big designer labels are another. But as design theorist Otto von Busch says, even fashion is like a totalitarian state: "Peers police each other and deploy acts of judgement, peer regulation and micro violence to uphold the aesthetic order of fashion supremacy." Whatever else you say about Kamala Surayya, she may not have fallen into the category of fashion victim. Her inner journey apparently didn't end too well; confidantes suggest she only barely stopped short of apostasy. As with all veiled truths, we don't know. ■

–With Aditya Wig